Iqtidar Alam Khan, because it gave Akbar paramount religious authority over his Muslim subjects alone, 'and not . . . the whole world'. For Abul Fazl, whose entire narrative presents Akbar as a universal king, the petition's limited scope would have been 'rather embarrassing'.

Indeed, Abul Fazl's ambitions for his emperor were boundless. Fairly early in the *Akbarnama*, the historian offers a quick summary of Akbar's ancestors, tracing them all the way back to Adam. This is not just fanciful padding. 'Very deliberately,' in fact, writes Harbans Mukhia, Abul Fazl's genealogy 'seeks to construct an alternative teleology of universal history' – a whole new way of understanding the story of humankind, that is – 'in which Akbar . . . would not be contained within the frame of a sect of humanity, i.e. Islam . . . heir not to Muhammad and the caliphs, but to Adam himself, the first human being, and thus the ruler of all humanity'.[22] For those who might argue that even Adam is particular to Semitic traditions, Abul Fazl may have an answer when he describes the Jain Tirthankaras as the 'twenty-four Adams' of the faith, the first of whom 'was Adinath, also called Raghunath'.[23]

Such happy incorporation of the many sects, religions and ethnicities of Hindustan in Akbar's embrace is the very foundation of the *Akbarnama*, though not original to it. The very idea of a 'sultan', in fact, as Richard Eaton argues, was that of a 'universal ruler', 'above all ethnic groups and religious communities'. It was an idea that grew over centuries in the Muslim world, following various historical developments, including the decline of the Abbasid Caliphate in Baghdad, that precipitated a split between religious and temporal power. Religious authority still vested in the caliph; but for the many sultans across the world who gave him their spiritual allegiance, managing increasingly diverse populations was the greater concern. Thus, Eaton continues, 'long before Renaissance or Enlightenment thinkers in Europe', scholars in Iran and Central Asia were propounding the separation of church and state. A twelfth-century Persian historian, Ibn Balkhi, for example, proposed this succinct tenet for temporal kingship: 'There is no kingdom without an army, no army without wealth, no wealth without material prosperity, and no material prosperity without justice.'[24]

Seen in this light, the mahzar went against the grain of both contemporary